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Wamkele Mene

(MEH-neh)

Secretary-General of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) Secretariat

Addressed as: **Secretary-General** | Office held since: **March 2020**

Secretary-General Mene is a dedicated trade diplomat who is racing to transform Africa's landmark trade agreement from a paper pact into commercially meaningful trade.

- **Self-Confident Negotiator**
  Mene regards himself as a skilled steward of Africa's economic integration, emphasizing his strengths in negotiation, legal expertise, and consensus-building. He boasts about his success in overcoming "extremely difficult and complicated industrial policy questions."

- **Implementation Obsesssed**
  Mene's "number one concern" is implementation and compliance—especially whether border officials will actually adhere to AfCFTA rules. When asked when intra-African trading will actually start, he admits "we are as anxious as anybody."

Mene has described the AfCFTA as more than a trade agreement, hailing it as a tool for "economic decolonization." He reminds counterparts that "we are on our own as a continent."

WHY THEY MATTER

Mene sits at the center of Africa's effort to create a 1.4-billion-person market—a project with major implications for trade finance, payments infrastructure, and market access.

- **Leveraging his Banking Expertise**
  Mene, who has an LLM in Banking Law and served as chairman of WTO Committee on International Trade in Financial Services, is fluent in financial and regulatory architecture.

- **Championing Signature Initiatives**
  Mene is a cheerleader for PAPSS (Pan-African Payment and Settlement System), seeking to reduce cross-border payment costs and enable local-currency settlement.

Mene's commitment to Pan-African ideals shows when he says he welcomes foreign support as long as integration remains "led by Africa for Africans."

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MEETING WITH THEM

Mene, who generally speaks with a calm, professional cadence, is always ready with a humorous quip or candid admission to make sure his message resonants.

- **A Cordial Interloctur**
  In private, Mene is formally warm—professional and resolute, focused on the legal and regulatory mechanics rather than rhetoric. He can be quiet and reserved, a reflection of his diplomatic training and possibly his fatigue from relentless travel.

- **An Irrelevant Aside**
  Mene will punctuate his remarks with surprisingly candid, sometimes humorous, asides that reveal his personality. On the challenges of managing African heads of state, he shared that "it is not easy to have 55 bosses, but I have to report to all of them."

Mene addresses challenges head-on, acknowledging implementation delays, infrastructure gaps, financing shortfalls, or skepticism about the AfCFTA. He uses historical and regional analogies to contextualize the difficulty of his task; he also cites European integration as a benchmark.

ON THEIR MIND

- **AGOA Extension**
  The House of Representatives in early January passed a bill to renew AGOA, Washington's preferential trade program, moving it to the Senate for a vote. The bill addresses Most Favored Nation (MFN) status, but retains President Trump's Liberation Day tariffs.

- **African Economic Growth**
  African economics are projected to grow by 4.4 percent this year–largely driven by commodities (especially metals). It marks a return to the region's quarter-century of successive expansion, which was disrupted by the COVID-19 pandemic.

- **Vegetable Bans**
  In December, Botswana imposed an import ban on vegetables, hindering efforts to facilitate intra-African trade. Banned goods included tomatoes, potatoes, cabbage, onions, watermelon, green papaya, beetroot, carrots, lettuce, strawberries, ginger, peppers, garlic, and butternut squash.

- **Construction of the African Trade Centre in Cairo**
  Afreximbank laid the first stone of its African Trade Centre, a strategic project aimed at strengthening intra-African trade and supporting AfCFTA implementation.

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NETWORK

Mene is seeking partnerships with major global powers, including the United States, but he is becoming increasingly vocal about disagreements with President Trump's trade policies.

Mene signed MoUs with China in 2021 and United States in 2022, and welcomed a UK support program. He has bristled at what he regards as Trump's "weaponization" and "disregard for trade rules," as well as the expiration of the AGOA preferential trade agreement.

The Secretary-General has strong working relations with several heads of states, including South African President Ramaphosa and Ghanaian President John Mahama whose country hosts the AfCFTA headquarters.

Mene's relationship with Ramaphosa was integral to his election as AfCFTA's first secretary-general; Mene had previously negotiated the trade agreement on Pretoria's behalf. Mene has carefully courted Mahama and his new administration, ensuring he retains the government's support during his stay in Ghana.

CONTROVERSIES

Mene has maintained a relatively positive public record, though his tenure has been marked by implementation gap critiques and rumors of friction with his Ghanaian staff.

- **Implementation Criticism**
  Critics note that despite broad ratification, active trading under AfCFTA preferences remains limited. The fragmentation of 54 economies with different regulatory regimes, infrastructure levels, and political priorities remains the central challenge.

- **Staffing Issues**
  In March 2021, reports circulated alleging Mene intended to sack all the Ghanaian employees at the Secretariat. Ghana's Ministry of Trade and Industry explicitly denied the story as "false and misleading."

Mene is sensitive to protocol and perceived slights, a disposition that occasionally leads to diplomatic tensions. He complained about a false-positive COVID test in Accra's airport in April 2021 and grumbled about security protocols when visiting the Eisenhower Executive Office Building in Washington, D.C. in the same year.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Secretary-General**, AfCFTA Secretariat (2020 - present)
- **Chief Director (Africa Economic Relations),** South African Department of Trade & Industry (2016-2020)
- **Director (International Trade & Investment Law)**, South African Department of Trade & Industry (2015-16)
- **Deputy Ambassador**, South African Mission to the WTO (2010-2015)
- **Attorney**, Simpson Thacher & Bartlett LLP (London)
- **Attorney**, Milbank, Tweed, Hadley & McCloy LLP (Hong Kong)

BIO

Mene's trajectory from Eastern Cape student politics to Africa's top trade post reflects an unusual blend of legal expertise, global finance experience, and deeply felt Pan-Africanism. Born in the township of KwaNobuhle near Uitenhage, Eastern Cape, South Africa, he credits Rhodes University mentors for pushing him onto a "non-traditional" international relations career path.

- **Academics & Politics**
  He earned a BA (Law) from Rhodes University, where he served as Student Representative Council (SRC) President in 1998. He later obtained an MA in International Studies & Diplomacy from SOAS (University of London) and an LLM in Banking Law and Financial Regulation from the London School of Economics.

- **Competitive Running**
  In a 2025 AfCFTA Podcast interview, Mene shared that he pursued competitive running on a full athletic scholarship at Rhodes University until knee injuries ended his professional aspirations in his early 20s. He credits this experience with instilling lifelong discipline, noting "you have to train six days a week... discipline is the key factor to succeeding as an athlete."

Mene is married to Malika Hinson, a corporate lawyer who was born in the Caribbean and raised in New York. They met at a Jazz and Arts Festival in St. Lucia. Mene speaks English, isiXhosa, and French but “only after midnight ... when I feel more relaxed.”

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